



The Girl Who Drew the Revolution

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Marjane Satrapi died in Paris on June 4, at fifty-six. She had drawn herself once as a small girl in a headscarf she did not want to wear, standing against a black panel, and that drawing went out into the world in thirty-three languages. The girl in the panel was angry and confused and ten years old. Readers in countries Satrapi had never seen knew exactly who she was.

2 Persepolis was not a grand book. It was small frames of black and white, a child watching her uncle taken away, a teenager sent alone to Vienna and sleeping for a stretch with nowhere to live [Imagery]. Satrapi published it in French in four thin volumes between 2000 and 2003, and Pantheon carried it into English soon after. By 2018 it had sold more than two million copies. Numbers like that usually belong to thrillers.

3 The book did one steady thing on every page. It refused to let a whole country become a headline. Where the news gave Iran a flag and a menace and a crowd, Satrapi gave it a grandmother, a maid, a cigarette smoked in secret, a Kim Wilde tape bought on a corner [Antithesis]. Her great-grandfather had ruled that country as a Qajar shah in the nineteenth century, a fact she wore lightly, the way you might mention an old house in the family. The history was enormous. She kept drawing the small thing inside it.

4 When the animated Persepolis reached Cannes in 2007 it took the Jury Prize, and the Academy nomination that followed made her the first woman ever named in the animated feature category [Asyndeton]. She did not stay in one form. There was Embroideries, where Iranian women talk about sex and marriage over an afternoon. There was a live-action film, a dark Hollywood comedy with Ryan Reynolds, a feature about Marie Curie. She kept moving.

5 Her husband, the Swedish producer Mattias Ripa, died of cancer in April 2025, after thirty-one years [Pathos]. She entered a clinic in Munich this spring. Her family said she died of sadness, a little more than a year after he was gone. It is an unmedical word, and they used it anyway [Diction].

6 The girl in the black panel is still there, in two million copies, in thirty-three languages, on shelves in rooms Satrapi will never enter. She made one country legible to the rest by drawing it the size of a child. That child outlasts her now.

Devices, and why they are here:

Imagery (paragraph 2): “Persepolis was not a grand book. It was small frames of black and white, a child watching her uncle taken away, a teenager sent alone to Vienna and sleeping for a stretch with nowhere to live”

The concrete black-and-white frames (a child watching an uncle taken, a teenager alone in Vienna) make the abstract praise of Persepolis felt rather than asserted; pathos lives in the seen detail, not in adjectives, exactly as the consecratory register requires.

Antithesis (paragraph 3): “Where the news gave Iran a flag and a menace and a crowd, Satrapi gave it a grandmother, a maid, a cigarette smoked in secret, a Kim Wilde tape bought on a corner”

The balanced contrast between the news (flag, menace, crowd) and Satrapi (grandmother, maid, cigarette, tape) drives the tribute's central small-versus-large opposition, naming what her work was for in one move.

Asyndeton (paragraph 4): “When the animated Persepolis reached Cannes in 2007 it took the Jury Prize, and the Academy nomination that followed made her the first woman ever named in the animated feature category”

Dropping conjunctions across the list of films and books speeds the rhythm and piles up her range, so her restlessness is enacted by the syntax rather than stated.

Pathos (paragraph 5): “Her husband, the Swedish producer Mattias Ripa, died of cancer in April 2025, after thirty-one years”

The bare report of the husband's death and the thirty-one years lands grief through fact and a counted number alone, refusing emotional vocabulary, which keeps the elegy dignified instead of sentimental.

Diction (paragraph 5): “It is an unmedical word, and they used it anyway”

Calling sadness an 'unmedical word' the family 'used anyway' turns on a single deliberate word choice, marking the gap between clinical cause and human truth without the writer commenting on it directly.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer contrasts how the news rendered Iran (a flag, a menace, a crowd) with what Satrapi rendered (a grandmother, a maid, a cigarette, a tape) primarily in order to
 - A) trace the chronological sequence of Satrapi's career
 - B) introduce the family history that the paragraph later mentions
 - C) define the particular work her drawings did against the abstraction of headlines
 - D) prove that news coverage of Iran was factually inaccurate
2. In the fifth paragraph, the short sentence calling sadness 'an unmedical word, and they used it anyway' best supports which characterization of the writer's tone toward the family's statement?
 - A) skeptical that grief could actually have caused her death
 - B) quietly respectful of a truth that exceeds clinical language
 - C) clinically detached from the question of how she died
 - D) openly grieving and unable to restrain emotion

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer C. The contrast names the function of Satrapi's art: it refuses to let a country collapse into headline-sized abstraction and insists on the small, particular life instead, which the paragraph's opening sentence states outright. The option about coverage being factually inaccurate fails as inverted relationship and over-broad: the writer never argues the news was false, only that it was large and faceless. The chronology option is true but not the function asked, since the contrast does no sequencing work. The family-history option is right effect, wrong location: the Qajar-shah detail appears later and serves a different, lighter purpose than the news-versus-Satrapi opposition.

2. Answer B. The line grants that 'sadness' is not a medical term, then honors the family's choice to use it, holding the human truth above the clinical one without raising its voice. The skeptical reading inverts the stance: 'used it anyway' endorses the word rather than doubting the cause. The clinically detached reading is too literal, mistaking the restraint for indifference when the restraint is itself the feeling. The openly grieving reading is over-broad and contradicts the controlled, understated delivery; the writer registers grief precisely by withholding emotional vocabulary, not by pouring it out.

Discussion questions:

1. The piece praises Persepolis for drawing a country 'the size of a child.' Where else in the opener does the writer make a large historical subject small and particular, and what does that scaling accomplish that a sweeping statement could not?
2. The final paragraph ends on the drawn girl rather than on Satrapi herself. Why might the writer choose to close on the work instead of the person, and how does that choice shape what the reader is left feeling?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The writer scales the enormous down to the human at almost every turn. The 1979 revolution arrives not as an event but as 'a child watching her uncle taken away.' Iran's politics become 'a grandmother, a maid, a cigarette smoked in secret.' Even Satrapi's royal ancestry, a shah who ruled in the nineteenth century, is shrunk to 'an old house in the family.' The scaling does what the tribute argues Persepolis itself did: it makes a faraway, headline-sized place legible by giving it a face and a body. A sweeping statement about Satrapi's cultural importance would assert significance; these small particulars let the reader feel it, which is the consecratory move the register depends on.
2. Closing on the drawn girl rather than on Satrapi places the meaning of her life into something that outlasts her, which is the tribute's job. The last lines insist the child is 'still there, in two million copies, in thirty-three languages, on shelves in rooms Satrapi will never enter.' By ending on the work, the writer hands the reader an inheritance instead of a final fact about the woman. The effect is consolation without sentimentality: we are left not with the death in Paris but with the durable image she made, and with the quiet claim that 'that child outlasts her now.'

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage is a short tribute written after the death of the Iranian-French cartoonist and filmmaker Marjane Satrapi on June 4, 2026. Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay in which you analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to honor Satrapi and to convey the meaning of her work. In your response you should do the following: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence from the passage to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; demonstrate an understanding of the passage's rhetorical situation. Consider, among other choices, the writer's use of concrete imagery, the contrast between how the news depicted Iran and how Satrapi depicted it, the handling of the family's statement that she 'died of sadness,' and the decision to close on the drawn girl rather than on Satrapi herself.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may read the news-versus-Satrapi contrast in paragraph three as an argument that journalism is bad or inaccurate. It is antithesis used consecratory, defining what her art did, not rebutting an opponent; the tribute register does not argue against a foe.

- Students may label the rapid list of films and books in paragraph four as anaphora because it feels like repetition. It is asyndeton (dropped conjunctions to speed and pile up range); nothing is repeated at the start of successive clauses, so the anaphora label does not fit.
- Students may treat 'died of sadness' as the writer's own medical claim about the cause of death. The opener attributes it to the family's statement and even flags it as 'unmedical,' so the phrase is reported characterization, not the writer asserting a diagnosis.
- Students may say the piece tells us Satrapi was important and moving. The opener almost never names emotion or significance directly; it shows them through concrete images and counted facts, which is why the imagery and pathos spans, not any stated adjective, carry the feeling.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches how a consecratory passage builds feeling through concrete imagery, antithesis, and restrained diction rather than asserted significance, and it gives students practice distinguishing look-alike devices (asyndeton from anaphora). The MCQs target Reasoning and Organization (the function of a contrast) and Style (tone conveyed by word choice), and the Q2 prompt asks students to analyze how an elegy honors its subject without arguing a claim.